

Archaeologists have found evidence of formal marriage contracts dating back 4,000 years. Marriage from the beginning was strategic, a way of preserving power, procuring land and producing heirs. Among the common folk, parents and relatives arranged matches to strengthen family ties, while kings and emperors married off their daughters to forge political alliances. Marriage was a union between two people that symbolized a much larger union between two families, tribes or nations. Children often had little say in choosing a mate, daughters especially. In China, there were even “ghost marriages,” where living girls were conjoined to deceased men as a goodwill gesture between clans. Being married to a corpse from a good family provided not only financial stability but a good deal of independence. These “widows” were treated respectfully as married woman while enjoying the freedom to pursue their own interests. In other words, they maintained their wealth and reputation, but they didn’t have to cook dumplings for their husband or pick up his dirty socks. It was a win-win.

For our ancestors, marriage was never about love or romance or sexual desire. It was about money, property and preserving the family lineage. This led to some rather strange practices among friends. Long before *Wife Swap* was a popular TV show, the ancient Romans were practicing their own version of a marriage exchange. Take Cato, a powerful statesman who was looking for ways to strengthen ties with Hortensius, a well-known Roman orator. Hortensius was a wealthy man and a lover of good wine—an all-around decent guy. But his one regret in life was that he didn’t have an heir. So Hortensius proposed that he marry Cato’s daughter. Cato wanted to get in good with the orator, but marrying his 20-year-old daughter to his 60-year-old friend was a bit much. Instead, Cato agreed to divorce Marcia, his own wife, to make her legally available. Hortensius liked the idea; he swept in, married Marcia and promptly got her pregnant, which gave him the heir he’d always wanted. In case you think Marcia got the short end of the stick, rest assured she made a tidy profit from this arrangement. When Hortensius died six years later, she inherited most of his considerable wealth, which included multiple villas and a handful of